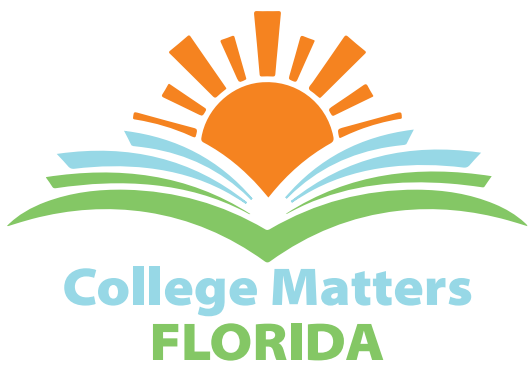




PROMISING PRACTICES

NUMBER 2

Using a Closed Facebook Group to Engage Families in Discussions about Postsecondary Education: Lessons Learned from the Parent Support Network

Program Background

Family Network on Disabilities (FND) is a family-centered, family-driven, grassroots organization founded in 1985 by a group of parents of children with disabilities who came together for mutual support and information-sharing. FND operates several family support programs throughout Florida including the Parent Support Network (PSN). FND's programs are designed to ensure that parents of children with the full range of disabilities and mental health challenges have the training and information they need to prepare for productive, independent lives. The PSN provides these supports to the following counties: Charlotte, Citrus, Collier, De Soto, Glades, Hardee, Hendry, Hernando, Highlands, Hillsborough, Lee, Manatee, Pasco, Pinellas, Sarasota, and Sumter. This program, funded by the US Department of Education Office of Special Education Programs (OSEP), is the Parent Training Information (PTI) center for Central and Northeast Florida.

In collaboration with Project 10 and Florida Consortium on Inclusive Higher Education, the PSN decided to create a closed Facebook group as a platform to share information about postsecondary education with families of young adults with disabilities, including those with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). PSN wanted to create a safe space where parents could connect and speak openly without fear as they navigated decisions about postsecondary education. They used synchronous and asynchronous features on Facebook to meet their goal of sharing resources in an engaging and innovative way.

Implementation

The PSN began by inviting parents via social media to join a closed Facebook group. They distributed a flyer broadly through their listserv. As parents began to join, PSN shared information in both English and Spanish. Once they were satisfied with the size of the group, PSN implemented a series of Watch Parties. The Watch Party feature on Facebook allows its users to simultaneously watch Facebook videos together. Their streams are synced so they can comment and react in real-time. This is a useful tool for participants joining from different locations or counties.

The PSN offered a series of nine Watch Parties focusing on transitioning from high school to postsecondary education. They wanted to deliberately share information that illustrated how students with IDD are attending college successfully. Some Watch Party topics included:

- the reasons and value of attending college
- new expectations
- financial aid options
- programs and other resources colleges offer throughout the state



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On average, up to 20 parents joined each of these events. PSN recorded and posted each Watch Party for viewing via a Facebook Playlist. Playlists let Facebook users organize videos based on themes or topics, and they can be arranged to play in any order. Therefore, the parents who could not attend the Watch Party were able to view the video recordings when it fit into their schedules. PSN uploaded nine videos from the Watch Party and other resources for the group as well.

Impact

Throughout the duration of the closed Facebook group, PSN encouraged parents, youth, and professionals to interact and connect with each other. Parents became more confident, and felt prepared to make informed decisions in conjunction with their young adult based on the resources and information shared in the group. Parents found comfort and security in navigating the decision around postsecondary education alongside a network of their peers. Finding a network of families around this topic allows parents to support one another through a critical part of the journey.

Suggestions for Replication

- A simple, closed Facebook group can be an excellent strategy for engaging parents and youth on a platform many parents already use and check regularly.
- A closed Facebook group can be a low-cost or no-cost way to bring a large number of parents from different geographic regions together to learn about a particular topic.
- Parents and programs can easily share resources and videos and the platform itself allows members to connect with one another via posting and replying.
- The Watch Party allowed parents to view content together and connect with one another synchronously and the Play List allowed parents to watch the content in a way that was self-paced and integrated into their busy schedules (asynchronously).
- Although Facebook no longer offers Watch Parties, holding a closed Facebook group with zoom sessions serves the same purpose! Recording each Zoom session and uploading it to the Facebook group would allow an asynchronous option for the parents who need it.

Additional Resources

- Visit Facebook for more information about [creating Facebook playlists](#).
- Join the [Family Network on Disabilities Facebook group](#)

For more information, please contact:

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